

A

Number and quantity

Number is used for countable nouns (e.g. a large number of students), **amount** for uncountable nouns (e.g. a large amount of money).

Some adjectives for expressing number and quantity:



Even **minute** amounts of toxic material can be dangerous. (*fml*)

Add just a **tiny** amount of chilli pepper, or else it may get too hot.

Were there many people at the airport? Oh, about **average**, I'd say. (*fairly informal*)

A **considerable** number of people failed to get tickets. (*fml*)

A **significant** number of students have dropped out of university in the last year.

[noticeably large]

Substantial amounts of money have been wasted on this project. (*fml*)

There is an **excessive** amount of sugar in many soft drinks. [*too much; rather formal*]

A **vast** / An **enormous** quantity of sand was blown on to the road during the storm.

B

Informal words for number/quantity

I've got **dozens of** nails in my tool box. [a dozen is 12; *dozens of* means many; especially used for countables]

Scores of people were injured when the gas tank exploded. [a score is 20 or about 20; *scores of* means a large number of; usually formal]

There's **heaps/bags/loads of** time yet, slow down! (usually with singular *there is*, not *there are*; countable or uncountable; *infml*)

There was absolutely **tons of** food at the party – far too much. (again, note singular *there was*; especially used for things, not so often used for abstract nouns)

There are **tons of** apples on this tree this year – last year there were hardly any.

(*Note*: The verb here is plural because of 'apples', but singular in the example before with 'food' – number depends on the *noun* following, not on **tons/lots/loads**.)

Just a **drop** of milk for me, please. [*tiny amount of any liquid*]

C

Degree and intensity: collocations with *utter(ly)*, *total(ly)*, *wholly*

Utter(ly), **total(ly)** and **wholly** mean complete(ly).

Utter combines with 'strong' nouns like *nonsense*, *contempt*, *silence*, *confusion*, *chaos* and *despair*.

There was **utter chaos** during the transport strike.

Utterly combines with adjectives such as *ridiculous*, *confused* and *impossible*.

I was **utterly confused** by the instruction manual that came with my camcorder!

Total combines most often with *disbelief* and *ban*, e.g. She looked at him in **total disbelief**. The government introduced a **total ban** on smoking in public places.

Totally combines most often with *different*, *unexpected*, *unsuitable* and *wrong*, e.g.

The two brothers have **totally different** personalities.

Wholly combines most often with *dependent*, *inadequate* and *unacceptable*, e.g.

The success of the project was **wholly dependent** on the weather.

Exercises

51.1 Complete the sentences with words from A opposite.

- 1 It takes a c onsiderable amount of time to learn to ski well.
- 2 As..... quantity of food is thrown away every day by supermarkets. It's a scandal. (two possible answers)
- 3 The scientists found only a m amount of the chemical in the food and said it was safe to eat.
- 4 We ate an e amount of food at dinner last night! (two possible answers)
- 5 V..... amounts of money are wasted by government departments every year.
- 6 The number of students registering for our courses is about a for the autumn semester.
- 7 At..... amount of water had got into the keyboard and it stopped working.
- 8 Last year we didn't really notice an increase in prices, but this year the increase has been s..... .

51.2 Use words from A to fill the gaps. More than one answer may be possible.

- 1 Even a tiny / minute amount of sand can damage a camera.
- 2 I've had an absolutely amount of work lately. I'm exhausted!
- 3 Oh, you've given me a amount of food here! I mustn't eat too much.
- 4 It takes a amount of money to start a business.
- 5 An amount of fat in your diet is dangerous.

51.3 Circle the most suitable answer. More than one may be correct.

- 1 Tons / Scores / Bags of people came on to the streets to hear his speech.
- 2 We've got loads / scores / dozens of time. The train doesn't leave till 2.30.
- 3 There was / were tons of food left over after the dinner party.
- 4 I've got heap / loads / dozens of CDs that I never play any more.
- 5 There was / were dozens of people waiting outside the building.

51.4 Using intensifiers from C, write what you could say in the following situations.

- 1 You thought someone's views were completely ridiculous. His/Her views were utterly ridiculous.
- 2 You read two novels by the same author which were completely different.
.....
- 3 You thought someone's behaviour was completely unacceptable.
.....
- 4 You thought a particular way of working produced chaos.
.....
- 5 You listened to someone's story and did not believe a word of it.
.....
- 6 You think there should be a complete ban on using mobile phones in cinemas.
.....

51.5 Over to you

Write sentences that are true for you using these collocations:
wholly dependent utterly confused totally unexpected utter nonsense